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Week in Review: X CEO Linda Yaccarino steps down

Welcome back to Week in Review! We've got tons of news for you this week, including a shakeup at X, Hugging Face's new robot, new phones from Nothing and Samsung, and a whole lot more. Have a great weekend!

Off to do something else: [X CEO Linda Yaccarino stepped down](#) this week after a tumultuous two-year tenure marked by advertiser backlash, Elon Musk's controversies, and the platform's AI troubles. The company's [ad business improved](#) under her leadership, but the road ahead will still be tough.

See-through: Apple continues to [tweak its new Liquid Glass design in iOS 26 beta 3](#), dialing back transparency in areas like Notifications and Apple Music after user complaints about readability. It's the latest step in finding the right balance before the OS launches this fall.

The cutest: Hugging Face has [opened orders for its new open source desktop robot](#), Reachy Mini, aimed at AI developers. Starting at \$299, the build-it-yourself bots are fully programmable in Python and integrated with the Hugging Face Hub.

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This is TechCrunch's Week in Review, where we recap the week's biggest news. Want this delivered

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- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines
- The best dating apps aren't even dating apps

News



NOTHING PHONE 3

IMAGE CREDITS: IVAN MEHTA

Whole lot of Nothing: Nothing's [\\$799 Phone \(3\)](#) is its most ambitious yet, with a quirky new second screen, AI features, and flagship specs aimed at rivaling Samsung and Apple. But mixed reactions to the design and pricing may keep it in “alternative to” rather than “replacement for” territory, at least for now.

Samsung, too: Samsung also [released new foldable phones](#) this week, the new Z Fold7 and the Z Flip7. It also released a cheaper foldable phone, the Z Flip7 FE.

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Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

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I want this car: Rivian's new [quad-motor R1T and R1S EVs are here](#), boasting 1,025 horsepower, getting you from 0 to 60 in under 2.5 seconds, and flashy new software tricks like “kick turn” and RAD Tuner for custom driving modes. With in-house motors and a deeper software stack, Rivian's betting this \$115,000+ flagship can hold the line until its more affordable R2s arrive in 2026.

Cool, awesome: Elon Musk says xAI's new Grok 4 is a “maximally truth-seeking AI,” but testing shows [the chatbot often consults Musk's own X posts](#) and public opinions when answering controversial questions. The model's alignment with its founder raises fresh concerns about objectivity and about Grok's readiness for prime time, [including being featured in Teslas](#), which Musk says is coming next week.

And another one: Apple's head of AI models, Ruoming Pang, [has left for Meta](#), where he'll join Zuckerberg's growing AI superintelligence unit. The move signals ongoing trouble in Apple's AI efforts and adds more on-device AI expertise to Meta's expanding bench.

Safety first? Jack Dorsey spent last weekend [building a Bluetooth-based messaging app](#) called Bitchat, which operates through Bluetooth mesh networks, letting users chat without Wi-Fi or cell service. The app is now in closed beta, but the

claims that the app is secure [are already facing scrutiny](#) by security researchers.

It's time: After 14 years inside Intel, [RealSense is spinning out as an independent company](#) with \$50 million in funding to scale its 3D stereoscopic imaging tech used in robotics, drones, and more. CEO Nadav Orbach aims to boost go-to-market efforts and improve safety features for human-robot interaction as AI-driven demand surges.

Analysis



SLATE AUTO'S ELECTRIC TRUCK.

IMAGE CREDITS:SLATE AUTO

Pulling back the curtain: Slate Auto, a stealthy Michigan-based EV startup backed by Jeff Bezos, [stunned the industry by unveiling plans](#) for an ultra-affordable, customizable electric pickup truck. After three years in the shadows, the company aims to shake up the market with production targeted for late 2026.

Topics: [Apple](#) [Elon Musk](#) [Grok](#) [jack dorsey](#)

[linda yaccarino](#) [Social](#) [Week in Review](#)



Karyne Levy

Deputy Managing Editor | X butterfly

Karyne Levy is the deputy managing editor of TechCrunch. Before joining TC, Karyne was deputy managing editor at...

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Apple finally supports RCS in iOS 18 update

Cody Corral — 1:15 PM PDT · June 29, 2024

IMAGE CREDITS: [RAWPIXEL.COM](https://www.rawpixel.com) / [SHUTTERSTOCK](https://www.shutterstock.com)

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This week, Apple finally added support for [Rich Communication Services](#) (RCS) to Messages as part of the second developer beta of iOS 18. Until now, iPhone users could only send SMS or MMS messages from the Messages app to people who didn't have an Apple device. Now you can share high-quality images and get read receipts and typing indicators while messaging with Android users — but text bubbles are still green.

OpenAI is delaying the release of [its new Voice Mode](#). The company had planned to start rolling out advanced Voice Mode in alpha to a small group of ChatGPT Plus users in late June but said that lingering issues forced it to postpone the launch to sometime in July. Depending on internal safety and reliability checks, Advanced Voice Mode might not launch for all ChatGPT Plus customers until the fall, the company says.

The FCC proposed an easier way for consumers [to unlock their phones](#) from their carriers, suggesting that all devices must be unlockable just 60 days after purchase. The rule would potentially allow phones to work with different mobile networks after that time period, but it may run afoul of today's phone and wireless markets.

News

OpenAI releases ChatGPT for Mac: ChatGPT is now available to all macOS users via a new app. Mac users can quickly call up ChatGPT by using the keyboard combination of Option + Space after

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Zuckerberg disses “closed” AI: In a new interview, the Meta CEO said he doesn't believe there will be “just one AI” and emphasized the importance of open source AI. Zuckerberg also said closed source AI competitors are trying to “create God.” [Read more](#)

Andrew Ng's AI Fund wants to raise a lot of cash: According to a new SEC filing, Andrew Ng's AI Fund plans to raise upward of \$120 million for its second effort. The startup incubator backs small teams of experts looking to solve key problems using AI. [Read more](#)

Gemini AI comes to Gmail: Google is rolling out a Gemini AI side panel in Gmail to help you draft emails and find information from your inbox. The Gemini side panel will also be available in Docs, Sheets, Slides, and Drive. [Read more](#)

OpenAI continues its M&A tear: OpenAI has acquired Multi, a startup developing an enterprise-focused, video-first collaboration platform. A source familiar with the matter tells TechCrunch that most of Multi's team will join OpenAI following the deal's close. [Read more](#)

An eerie smiling robot with living skin: Will robots ever have living, human skin? Researchers at the University of Tokyo and Harvard have been exploring the question — and they've come up with some pretty unsettling results. [Read more](#)

Meta's chatbots head to India: After a few months of testing during the general elections, Meta is making its Llama 3-powered AI chatbot available to all users in India. But Meta AI currently only supports English. [Read more](#)

Prosus zeroes out its stake in Byju's: One of Byju's largest investors said its once-\$2.1 billion stake in the Indian edtech startup is now worth nothing. However, Prosus is still hopeful that Byju's can be salvaged. [Read more](#)

Analysis

Silicon Valley is being weird about DEI again: DEI has become incredibly divisive. A prime example of the tension is the conversation sparked by startup Scale AI founder Alexandr Wang, in which he discussed moving away from DEI to instead embrace "MEI" — merit, excellence, and intelligence. But Dominic-Madori Davis and Kyle Wiggers write that, according to the data, a "meritocracy" is not better than DEI. [Read more](#)

What Ayana Parsons' resignation means: Fearless Fund's co-founder Ayana Parsons is stepping down. The announcement follows continued legal trouble and the pendulum swing in tech that has resulted in increased anti-DEI sentiment. Julie Bort and Dominic-Madori Davis explore how the latest developments for Fearless Fund, and the switch to publicly panning DEI, are a sad reflection on the VC world for Black women. [Read more](#)

Topics: [Apple](#) [DEI](#) [RCS](#) [Social](#) [Week in Review](#)



Cody Corral

Cody Corral was the Audience Development Producer at TechCrunch until March 2025. They also previously ran...

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Apple, Disney, Comcast
among X advertisers
pausing spending after

Musk endorsed antisemitic post

Amanda Silberling — 7:55 AM PST · November 20, 2023

After X owner Elon Musk amplified antisemitic conspiracy theories on the platform, numerous high-profile advertisers have paused their spending on the platform formerly known as Twitter.

Since Friday, per [various news reports](#), the following advertisers have paused their spending on X advertisements:

Apple

Comcast/NBCUniversal

IMAGE CREDITS:
SAMUEL CORUM / CONTRIBUTOR / GETTY IMAGES
Disney

Warner Bros. Discovery

IBM

Paramount Global

Lionsgate

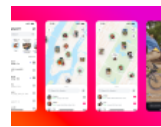
European Commission

Per research from the Center for Countering Digital Hate, X has [failed to moderate](#) hate speech on its platform that promotes antisemitic conspiracies, praises Hitler and dehumanizes Muslims and Palestinians. But X isn't just keeping these posts up; its owner, Elon Musk, is fanning the flames of such

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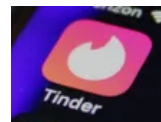
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Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik - 21 hours ago

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Ivan Mehta - 21 hours ago

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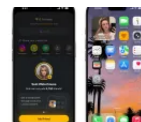


Photo-sharing app Locket is banking on a new celebrity-focused feature to fuel its growth

Lauren Forristal

- 22 hours ago

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hatred. In a particularly egregious incident last week, Musk replied, “[You have said the actual truth](#)” to a post that echoed the same violent antisemitic conspiracy theory that was espoused by the killer from the 2018 [Tree of Life synagogue](#) attack.

[Backlash builds after Elon Musk called an antisemitic conspiracy theory the ‘actual truth’](#)

Media Matters for America, a left-leaning media watchdog, [published a separate report last week](#), showing how ads from companies like Apple, IBM, Bravo, Oracle and Xfinity have appeared next to posts that praise Nazi ideology. In a statement, X said that the report “completely misrepresented the real user experience on X, in another attempt to undermine freedom of speech and mislead advertisers.” Throughout his tenure as X’s owner, Musk has sued or threatened to sue nonprofit organizations like the [Center for Countering Digital Hate](#) and the [Anti-Defamation League](#), alleging that their reports are responsible for the increasingly tenuous relationship between X and advertisers.

“The split second court opens on Monday, X Corp will be filing a thermonuclear lawsuit against Media Matters and ALL those who colluded in this fraudulent attack on our company,” Musk wrote in a post on X.



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In a statement that Musk posted, X claims that Media Matters deceived advertisers and engineered a contrived experience on the platform in order to view ads alongside antisemitic content. Media Matters highlighted nine posts that the organization believes should violate X's content policies, but X said only one post was found to be in violation and taken down. X seems to have suspended an account that denied the historical legitimacy of the Holocaust, but did not take action against a post that refers to Nazism as a "spiritual awakening," or posts that praise white supremacist Nazi ideals.

The split second court opens on Monday, X Corp will be filing a thermonuclear lawsuit against Media Matters and ALL those who colluded in this fraudulent attack on our company
pic.twitter.com/55vl7PspaQ

— Elon Musk (@elonmusk) [November 18, 2023](#)

Linda Yaccarino, X's new CEO and former advertising executive at NBCUniversal, has attempted to calm advertisers, though her efforts don't seem to be working, as advertisers continue to pause spending.

"X's point of view has always been very clear that discrimination by everyone should STOP across the board — I think that's something we can and should all agree on," she wrote on Thursday afternoon.

"When it comes to this platform — X has also been extremely clear about our efforts to combat antisemitism and discrimination. There's no place

for it anywhere in the world — it's ugly and wrong.
Full stop.”

X's point of view has always been very clear that discrimination by everyone should STOP across the board — I think that's something we can and should all agree on. When it comes to this platform — X has also been extremely clear about our efforts to combat antisemitism and...

— Linda Yaccarino (@lindayaX) [November 16, 2023](#)

X's advertising business has been [volatile](#) since last year, when Elon Musk officially became the owner of the platform formerly known as Twitter. About a month after he took over, Musk tweeted that Apple had “[mostly stopped advertising on Twitter.](#)” But after [meeting with Apple CEO Tim Cook](#) at the company's Cupertino headquarters, the two seemed to settle some disagreements. Then, in January, the company inked deals with adtech companies [DoubleVerify](#) and [Integral Ad Science \(IAS\)](#) to help advertisers make sure their ad is not placed around inappropriate content, and the [appointment of Yaccarino](#) in May was supposed to assuage advertiser's concerns about the increasingly hostile platform. But Musk continues to dig the platform's own grave by alienating key revenue drivers.

The Biden White House releases a statement on Elon Musk [pic.twitter.com/QZJnJuRT2K](#)

— Aaron Blake (@AaronBlake) [November 17, 2023](#)

As Musk continues to entertain antisemitic conspiracies, the White House weighed in with a [statement](#) condemning the promotion of antisemitic and racist hate.

“It is unacceptable to repeat the hideous lie behind the most fatal act of Antisemitism in American history at any time, let alone one month after the

deadliest day for the Jewish people since the Holocaust,” wrote White House spokesperson Andrew Bates. “We condemn this abhorrent promotion of Antisemitic and racist hate in the strongest terms, which runs against our core values as Americans.”

Update, 11/20/23 at 11:00 AM ET, with information about additional advertisers pausing spending.

[Elon Musk’s Twitter hit with Holocaust denial hate speech lawsuit in Germany](#)

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Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She...

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